

Viking voyages
Norwegian Vikings sailed prodigious distances, reaching Iceland by 860 and North America by 1000. Meanwhile, Swedish Vikings navigated the rivers of Russia as far as Constantinople and even the Caspian Sea.



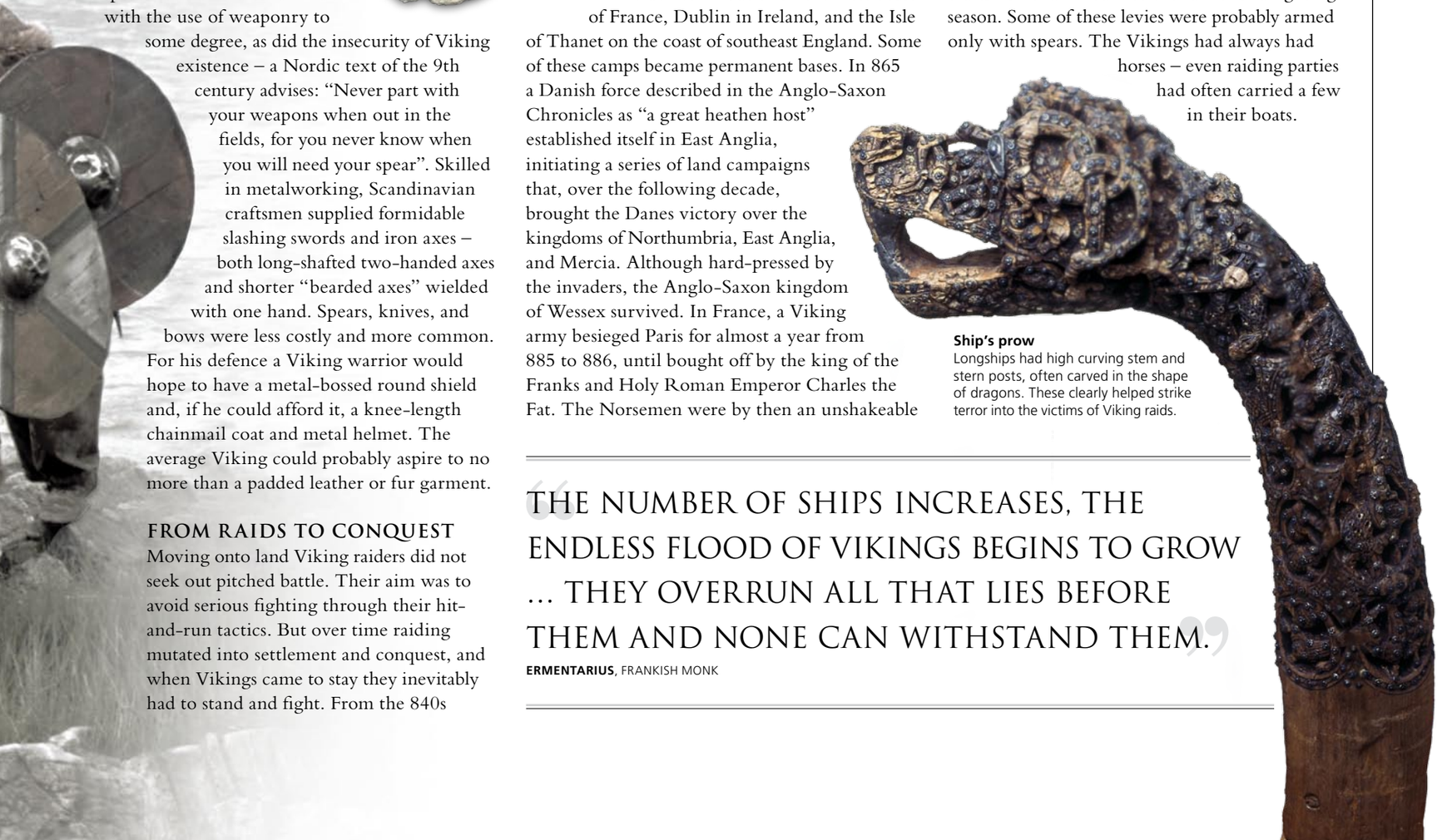
Gotland picture stone
The top of this 8th-century carved stone from the Swedish island of Gotland depicts warriors entering Valhalla – the eight-legged horse is Odin's steed Sleipnir. The lower part of the picture shows a Viking longship.

Specific military training was probably more or less nonexistent among the Scandinavian peoples. The basic skills of sailing and of warfare were simply part of everyday life. Hunting and sport made all males familiar with the use of weaponry to some degree, as did the insecurity of Viking existence – a Nordic text of the 9th century advises: "Never part with your weapons when out in the fields, for you never know when you will need your spear". Skilled in metalworking, Scandinavian craftsmen supplied formidable slashing swords and iron axes – both long-shafted two-handed axes and shorter "bearded axes" wielded with one hand. Spears, knives, and bows were less costly and more common. For his defence a Viking warrior would hope to have a metal-bossed round shield and, if he could afford it, a knee-length chainmail coat and metal helmet. The average Viking could probably aspire to no more than a padded leather or fur garment.

FROM RAIDS TO CONQUEST

Moving onto land Viking raiders did not seek out pitched battle. Their aim was to avoid serious fighting through their hit-and-run tactics. But over time raiding mutated into settlement and conquest, and when Vikings came to stay they inevitably had to stand and fight. From the 840s warbands started wintering at fortified camps at sites such as the Ile de Noirmoutier on the west coast of France, Dublin in Ireland, and the Isle of Thanet on the coast of southeast England. Some of these camps became permanent bases. In 865 a Danish force described in the Anglo-Saxon Chronicles as "a great heathen host" established itself in East Anglia, initiating a series of land campaigns that, over the following decade, brought the Danes victory over the kingdoms of Northumbria, East Anglia, and Mercia. Although hard-pressed by the invaders, the Anglo-Saxon kingdom of Wessex survived. In France, a Viking army besieged Paris for almost a year from 885 to 886, until bought off by the king of the Franks and Holy Roman Emperor Charles the Fat. The Norsemen were by then an unshakeable presence, a fact recognized by the Franks in granting them control of Normandy in 911. In the east, other groups of Vikings established kingdoms centred on Novgorod and Kiev.

The land armies formed by the Vikings still had a substantial core of warriors functioning as warbands, but larger forces would also include a considerable number of ordinary farmers or craftsmen drummed into the ranks for a fighting season. Some of these levies were probably armed only with spears. The Vikings had always had horses – even raiding parties had often carried a few in their boats.



Ship's prow
Longships had high curving stem and stern posts, often carved in the shape of dragons. These clearly helped strike terror into the victims of Viking raids.

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>
> **ERMENTARIUS**, FRANKISH MONK